



Alfalfa has been cultivated for centuries for its nutritional and medicinal properties.

History & Folklore Though mostly used as an animal feed, alfalfa seeds have been consumed as food for thousands of years. Pliny (23–79 CE) records that alfalfa was brought to Greece by Darius, King of Persia (550–486 BCE), during his attempt to conquer Athens.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Alfalfa is perhaps more therapeutically useful as a food than a medicine as the seeds are taken to help lower cholesterol levels. In view of alfalfa's estrogenic activity, it can prove useful in treating problems relating to menstruation and menopause.

Cautions Do not take alfalfa alongside the anticoagulant medication warfarin. Avoid sprouted seeds in compromised immune states. Using large amounts is not advisable in pregnancy or in autoimmune diseases.

Melaleuca leucadendron (Myrtaceae)

Cajuput

Description Aromatic, evergreen tree growing to 130 ft (40 m). Has peeling bark, pale green oval leaves, and clusters of small white flowers on long spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Southeast Asia, cajuput is cultivated for its essential oil and timber. The leaves and twigs are gathered throughout the year.

Part Used Essential oil.

Constituents The volatile oil contains terpenoids, mainly cineole (50–60%), beta-pinene, alpha-terpineol, and others. Cineole is strongly antiseptic. Early investigations suggest the fruit may have antiviral properties.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Cajuput is normally combined with other essential oils such as eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96). Its antiseptic

properties treat colds, sore throats, coughs, and, especially, chest infections. The diluted oil may either be steam-inhaled or applied to the chest or throat to treat laryngitis, tracheitis, and bronchitis. As cajuput stimulates the circulation and is antispasmodic, it is used as a friction rub for rheumatic joints and neuralgia.

Related Species Niaouli (*M. viridiflora*), of New Caledonia, has properties similar to those of cajuput. See also tea tree (*M. alternifolia*, p. 112).

Cautions Take internally only under professional supervision. Do not use during pregnancy. Cajuput essential oil is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Self-help Use Chest coughs & bronchitis, p. 310.

Melilotus officinalis syn. *M. arvensis* (Fabaceae) Melilot

Description Biennial herb growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has 3-lobed leaves, spikes of yellow flowers, and brown seedpods.



Melilot is an effective remedy for venous disorders.

Habitat & Cultivation Melilot is native to Europe, North Africa, and temperate regions of Asia, and is naturalized in North America. It grows in dry and open areas. It is harvested in late spring.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Melilot contains flavonoids, coumarins, resin, tannins, and volatile oil. If allowed to spoil, the plant produces dicoumarol, a powerful anticoagulant.

History & Folklore The Irish herbalist K'Eogh reported in 1735, "a gentlewoman of my acquaintance ... had a swelling for a year or more on her right side, which was cured by three or four times rubbing the grieved part with an oil made of this herb."

Medicinal Actions & Uses As with horse chestnut (*Aesculus hippocastanum*, p. 58), long-term use of melilot—internally or externally—can help varicose veins and hemorrhoids. Melilot also helps reduce the risk of phlebitis and thrombosis. The plant is mildly sedative and antispasmodic, and is given for insomnia (especially in children) and anxiety. It has been used to treat flatulence, indigestion, bronchitis, problems associated with menopause, and rheumatic pains.

Cautions Do not take melilot if using anticoagulants. If harvested from the wild, melilot should be dried or used immediately, as the spoiled plant is toxic.

Mentha haplocalyx (Lamiaceae) Bo He (Chinese), Corn Mint

Description Perennial herb growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has a square stem, oval toothed leaves, and whorls of pale lilac flowers growing from the leaf axils.

Habitat & Cultivation *Bo he* is native to temperate regions of the northern hemisphere, and is widely cultivated in China. Harvested 2–3 times a year, the best crops are in early summer and early autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents *Bo he* contains a volatile oil comprising mainly menthol (up to 95%) with menthone, menthyl acetate, camphene, limonene, and other terpenoids.

History & Folklore *Bo he* was first mentioned in *Grandfather Lei's Discussion of Herb Preparation* (c. 470 CE). A 15th-century Chinese prescription recommends *bo he* for dysentery with blood.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine (see pp. 40–43) *bo he* is a popular treatment for colds, sore throats, sore mouth and tongue, and a host of other conditions ranging from